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The Great Indian Migration Wave

Mere piya gaye Rangoon, kiya hai vahan se telephone,
Tumhaari yaad sataati hai, jiya mein aag lagaati hai.

—*Patanga*, 1949

Shamshad Begum's famous song in a classic Hindi film about a wife bemoaning her migrant husband's absence in the middle of the 20th century echoes the feelings of millions of women before and since. The long wait, first for the postman to deliver letters and then for fleeting reunions, has been a perennial source of anguish for separated families. Rangoon in Burma, now Yangon in Myanmar, happened to be one of the important places in the world that saw many Indian migrants in the early 20th century, but similar voices can be unearthed across the world in songs, letters and books across eras. In the Philippines today, one can hear of husbands bemoaning the absence of their wives who head to the US for work.

What makes the Indian case unique is the sheer persistence and magnitude of this phenomenon, one that has lasted for well over a century now. It is also a phenomenon that affects regions covering at least 20 per cent of the Indian population, currently comprising over 200 million people. I call it the 'Great Indian Migration Wave', and it ranks among the largest and longest migration streams for work in documented history. It led to the